WEEK 09 / COMMUNITIES, CREATIVITY, AND PLAYER CULTURE

Indie Games

The rise of indie games and the shift toward player-driven development.

This week we discuss the rise of indie games and the shift toward player-driven development, exploring how independent developers are shaping the gaming landscape and the unique experiences they offer.

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31 RESOURCES / 1 TOPIC

TOPIC 01

Independent Games and Development

REQUIRED

The Creativity of Indie Video Games

YOUTUBE | ~8 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=M-2zIemV2yc&ab_channel=PBSoffbook

This PBS Digital Studios video celebrates the creative freedom and innovation inherent in indie video game development. It explains how small teams, driven by artistic visions rather than commercial pressures, are able to push the boundaries of game design, mechanics, storytelling, and aesthetics. The video argues that indie games are crucial for the evolution of the medium, enabling new and unique experiences that might not be funded in the traditional commercial sphere.

Some highlights:

Indie games are driven by "small teams and tight artistic visions," granting developers the freedom to explore "crazy ideas" and push the boundaries of game design.
They are considered "saviors of video games" because they prioritize expression over profit, leading to innovative art styles, mechanics, and storytelling methods.
Crowdfunding platforms like Kickstarter and IndieGoGo are highlighted as vital tools that enable prototypes to secure funding and build an audience, allowing games to exist that otherwise wouldn't.
Indie developers focus on "systemic significance" in mechanics, aiming to create emotional feelings and encourage players to engage with challenges.
They excel in sound design, creating immersive soundscapes for abstract worlds, and visuals, which serve as "infographics" to convey information harmoniously with the game's aesthetic and mood.
Interactivity in indie games adds a "third dimension to storytelling," allowing players to actively shape the narrative and experience a greater emotional and personal impact.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

Independent games for your soul

TED TALK | ~21 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bc5J9So7f9s&ab_channel=TEDxTalks

This TEDx talk by Charlie Moseley advocates for the profound emotional impact of independent games, arguing that they speak to human beings on a deeper level than mere intellectual stimulation. Drawing on personal experiences and examples of specific indie titles (Firewatch, Undertale, Stardew Valley, Papers, Please, That Dragon, Cancer, Journey), Moseley illustrates how these games explore complex emotional states, human connections, moral dilemmas, and personal fulfillment, offering unique and memorable experiences. He also touches on the industry's focus on data over emotional impact and the growth of indie game communities.

A few highlights:

Moseley argues that games, particularly independent ones, have the capacity for profound emotional impact, speaking to players on a deeper level than just intellectual engagement.
He highlights several indie games as examples of this emotional range:
- Firewatch: Explores coping with loss and grief.
- Undertale: Focuses on feelings of being an outsider in a new world and finding acceptance.
- Stardew Valley: Emphasizes self-discovery and fulfilling one's destiny by choosing a new path in life.
- Papers, Please: Forces players to confront difficult moral choices with no easy answers in a dystopian setting.
- That Dragon, Cancer: A heartbreaking game about coping with the tragic loss of a child, showcasing both immense joy and crushing disappointment.
- Journey: A metaphor for facing challenges and adversity in life.
- He believes that while the gaming industry often focuses on statistical data and economic metrics, the emotional impact of games is an "overlooked aspect" that has a hugely positive effect on society.

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REQUIRED

Making a Name in Games

ARTICLE | ~35 MIN

https://maine.primo.exlibrisgroup.com/permalink/01MAINE_INST/1oa9cn5/cdi_proquest_journals_1319284231

This academic article analyzes the Difference Engine Initiative (DEI), a Toronto-based incubator designed to support women in game development. It frames the initiative within the concept of a "social network market," exploring how various commercial, cultural, and governmental entities interact with differing agendas. The article highlights the significant, often unpaid, "feminized affective labour" contributed by female participants, and critiques the underlying "postfeminist" ethos that views gender equality as achieved, thereby shifting the burden of success onto individual effort rather than addressing systemic inequities within the male-dominated game industry.

A few highlights:

The game industry is heavily male-dominated, with women making up, at most, 10% of the workforce, primarily in non-development roles, contributing to an exclusionary "hegemony of play".
The Difference Engine Initiative (DEI) was created in Toronto to address this imbalance by supporting women in developing their first digital games, providing skills, community, and networking opportunities.
The DEI operated within a complex "social network market" involving diverse partners (government, cultural

organizations, tech companies) with often conflicting agendas and power dynamics.
The female participants, positioned at the bottom of this hierarchy, contributed unpaid "affective, immaterial, and other value-creating labour" (e.g., community building, self-promotion) that ultimately benefited more powerful actors by promoting an image of digital innovation.
A key misalignment existed between organizers' focus on "product" (quantity of games made by women) and participants' desire for "process" (addressing systemic inequalities and gaining individual recognition), leading to participants taking on additional unpaid labor to achieve their goals.
The initiative exemplifies a "postfeminist vision" in the industry, which suggests that gender equality is already achieved and success is solely dependent on individual motivation, thereby overlooking and perpetuating systemic barriers and precarious labor conditions.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

The History of Indie Games

YOUTUBE | ~18 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=xtZ2sJt4S9Y&ab_channel=SaveData

This YouTube video provides a historical overview of indie games, tracing their origins from early PC shareware to their contemporary status as a cornerstone of the gaming industry. It offers a broad definition of "indie" based on scope, team size, budget, and creative control. The video emphasizes how digital distribution platforms like Steam, pioneered by Valve, and later support from console marketplaces (e.g., Xbox Live Arcade), were pivotal in making indie games widely accessible and popular, leading to their mainstream acceptance.

Some highlights:

The term "indie game" typically refers to games with a specific vision, simple concept taken to an extreme, made by small teams (or individuals) on tiny/no budgets, and often self-published without major publisher influence.
Indie games have "always existed" on PC, with shareware being crucial for early distribution by allowing byte-sized demos to be shared via floppy disks or bulletin boards.
- Digital distribution, notably pioneered by Valve with Steam in 2004 (with Half-Life 2), revolutionized game publishing, making it cheaper and easier for developers to release games directly, cutting out traditional middlemen.
- Console platforms, such as Xbox Live Arcade with Braid in 2008, began partnering with and promoting indie developers, further cementing their mainstream presence and accessibility.
- The rise of streaming, crowdfunding, and specialized indie publishers has made indie games a "mainstay of the gaming world," often appealing due to their shorter length, uniqueness, and affordability compared to AAA titles.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

REQUIRED

How One Person Changed Indie Games Forever

YOUTUBE | ~22 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=d0Lqt-BHbJ0&ab_channel=ThatGuyGlen

This YouTube video chronicles the remarkable journey of Daisuke Amaya, also known as "Pixel," the solo developer behind the influential indie game Cave Story. It explores his passion for game development as a hobby, his persistence in refining his skills and vision over five years, and how the game's exceptional quality led to its unexpected global success despite a lack of marketing or commercial intent. The video emphasizes Cave Story's profound impact on the indie game scene, paving the way for other solo developers and contributing to the resurgence of the Metroidvania genre.

A few highlights:
- Daisuke Amaya, known as "Pixel," single-handedly developed Cave Story over five years, initially as a hobby while working a low-paying job to afford development time.
 The game's success, despite being released for free with no marketing budget, stemmed from its sheer quality and the intrigue surrounding its mysterious lone developer.
 Cave Story is recognized for its significant impact on the indie game industry, proving that a single developer can craft a "deep, compelling action game" and paving the way for subsequent indie hits and the Metroidvania genre's resurgence.
 Amaya's commitment to making a game "people to enjoy rather than me creating just to create" led him to scrap two years of work after receiving critical feedback from a friend.
 He eventually transitioned to being a full-time indie developer in 2011, supported by the game's commercial releases on various platforms.

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REQUIRED

The Importance of Indie Games

YOUTUBE | ~20 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=iTwMqlDC35A&ab_channel=iFrames

This YouTube video argues that indie games are fundamental to the health and evolution of the gaming industry. It critically contrasts the characteristics of indie games (small teams, limited budgets, creative freedom, focus on innovation and gameplay) with those of many AAA titles (large budgets, long development times, risk aversion, focus on mass appeal and superficial aesthetics). The video contends that indie developers' willingness to take creative risks and prioritize core gameplay results in more impactful and valuable experiences for players.

A few highlights:

 Indie games are presented as essential for the gaming industry by offering "small but impactful experiences" that counteract the "homogenized and bloated" nature of many AAA titles.
 Unlike AAA developers who often play it safe due to high budgets, indie developers are "forced to take the right risks" and are "inspired and excited" to innovate and experiment, prioritizing gameplay and fun.
 Indie games offer high value due to their lower price point and often incorporate high replayability (e.g., roguelikes).
 Indie developers contribute to the gaming ecosystem by cultivating new talent and encouraging innovation, making game development more accessible through tools and free learning resources.

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REQUIRED

How Indie Games BEAT The AAA Industry

YOUTUBE | ~13 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-EGICLW1LqQ&ab_channel=GoingIndie

This video argues that indie games are "dominating" the video game industry by retaining a focus on fun and creative vision, contrasting sharply with the profit-driven approach of many triple-A (AAA) studios. It suggests that early games were inherently "indie" due to being made by small teams, prioritizing fun over complex graphics. The video illustrates this shift by comparing Bungie's passion-driven development of Halo with 343 Industries' subsequent, more profit-focused management of the franchise, which allegedly led to a decline in quality. It criticizes the AAA industry's adoption of live service models and microtransactions, which often result in unfinished games at launch. In stark contrast, successful indie studios like Supergiant Games (Hades) prioritize "following the fun" and actively engaging with their community, exemplified by Hades' two-year Early Access period dedicated to community feedback. The video concludes that the "Golden Age of Indie Games" is fueled by indie studios' culture of creative passion and desire to make games they themselves want to play, leveraging easier access to development tools and publishing platforms.

Some highlights:

The video asserts that indie studios are outperforming AAA by prioritizing fun and creative vision, contrasting with AAA's focus on profit-driven models and microtransactions.
Successful indie developers, like Supergiant Games with Hades, leverage community engagement and early access to build games that players love, embodying a return to the passion-driven approach of early game development.
- New tools and simplified publishing platforms have contributed to the "Golden Age of Indie Games," enabling developers to make and release games based on personal passion.

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REQUIRED

Peak Selling 1 Million Copies Proves That Video Games Just Need To Be Genuine

ARTICLE | ~6 MIN

https://www.thegamer.com/peak-sells-one-million-copies-indie-game-video-games-need-to-be-genuine/

This article examines the phenomenal success of recent indie games like Peak, Lethal Company, and Content Warning. It posits that these games thrive because they are "genuine," created with passion and a primary focus on delivering fun experiences, rather than being driven by strict sales targets or corporate demands. The author argues that this approach allows indie titles to often surpass the commercial performance of larger, triple-A productions.

A few highlights:
- Indie games like Peak achieve immense popularity by being "genuine," made with passion and a focus on fun, rather than being driven by sales targets or corporate demands.
- Peak notably sold 100,000 copies in its first 24 hours and climbed to 1 million copies in less than a week, with its peak player count exceeding 100,000.
- The success of these indie titles suggests that large budgets, harsh deadlines, and crunch are not prerequisites for success; instead, developers should prioritize making games they genuinely want to play.

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REQUIRED

Everything You Need To Start Making Games (As A Beginner)

YOUTUBE | ~17 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=_eK26atXTds&ab_channel=JuniperDev

This YouTube video provides comprehensive guidance for beginners looking to start game development. It covers fundamental decisions like choosing a game engine versus an IDE, effective coding practices to avoid "tutorial hell," and managing artistic and musical elements. The video stresses the importance of organizational tools and, perhaps most crucially, finding and engaging with a supportive community for feedback and motivation.

For beginners, choosing a game engine (such as Unity, Godot, or GameMaker) is generally recommended over raw coding in an IDE, as engines offer built-in features for game development.
To effectively learn coding and engine navigation, beginners should avoid "tutorial hell" by actively understanding the code they copy and consistently consulting documentation.
Initially, it's advisable to prioritize core game development (coding, logic) over creating original art, using free assets from engine stores. Pixel art is suggested as a more accessible art form for beginners due to its lower learning curve.
Organization tools like Microsoft OneNote, Notion, or Trello are crucial for tracking progress and staying motivated, especially since much of game development isn't immediately visible in the game itself.
- Building a community (e.g., Discord servers, clubs, game jams on Itch.io) is highlighted as infinitely beneficial for sharing projects, receiving feedback, brainstorming, and maintaining motivation.

Also check out the Juniper Dev YouTube channel (https://www.youtube.com/@JuniperDev). Here are some other specific channel video suggestions:
- Make Tiny Games. (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YtylfQq2JII&ab_channel=JuniperDev) (15 min)
This YouTube video discusses the educational and practical benefits of focusing on "tiny games" for aspiring developers, based on a university course experience using the Pico-8 engine. It emphasizes that starting with small, manageable projects, like arcade game recreations, helps beginners master fundamental mechanics and coding. The video also highlights the iterative design process, the crucial role of playtesting for feedback, and the significant positive impact of community and collaborative learning.
Developing "tiny games" using simplistic, retro engines like Pico-8 is an effective approach for beginners to learn game development fundamentals without being overwhelmed by complex ideas.
Recreating classic arcade games (e.g., Flappy Bird, Lunar Lander) helps developers focus on core mechanics and coding principles, providing a solid foundation.
Playtesting is vital for getting actionable feedback and refining game design, as developers often become "blind" to their own game's difficulty or issues.
Community interaction and peer learning (e.g., in-person classes, sharing projects) significantly enhances the development experience and provides crucial support and motivation.
The video suggests prioritizing a "fun mechanic or a fun gameplay loop" before worrying about the story or narrative, as this can lead to more successful game ideas.
The Subtle Details That Make Hollow Knight Great (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vxt8uud5o_4&ab_channel=JuniperDev) (17 min)
This YouTube video conducts a deep dive into the intricate design elements that make Hollow Knight an exceptional game. It meticulously breaks down how subtle visual techniques like parallax and black overlays create environmental depth, how finely-tuned movement physics contribute to a responsive and satisfying platforming experience, and how rich sound design enhances immersion. The video also highlights the game's masterful use of environmental storytelling and non-numerical progression, which prioritize player feeling and discovery over explicit information.
- Hollow Knight employs subtle visual techniques like parallax scrolling and intentional black overlays to create a sense of depth and seamless transitions between areas without obstructing the player's view.
The game's highly refined movement physics, including variable jump height, "coyote time" (allowing jumps

slightly off ledges), jump queuing, and momentum, contribute to an incredibly responsive and satisfying platforming experience.
Detailed sound design with a wide variety of effects for interactions, environments, and character sounds (both diegetic and non-diegetic) significantly enhances the game's atmosphere and provides crucial player feedback.
- Hollow Knight excels at "showing instead of telling" its story and lore through environmental storytelling, minimal cutscenes, and abstract narratives that encourage player discovery and inference.
- The game often uses non-numerical progression (no damage numbers, boss health bars, or visible levels), which intensifies combat and makes upgrades feel more impactful through "feeling" the difference in gameplay rather than seeing explicit stats.

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REQUIRED

How Much Our First Indie Game Made | No Marketing

YOUTUBE | ~12 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=L9d--sCmGS4

This YouTube video tells the story of Nessie Games, a small indie studio founded by Michelle and Steve, and their journey with their first released game, Checkout. It details how, despite having no prior industry experience, minimal marketing efforts, and even missing their initial release date, the game achieved unexpected financial success. The video attributes this success to the game's polish, unique concept, and inherent quality, suggesting that "good games find their audience."

A few highlights:
- Nessie Games, a two-person indie studio, achieved significant financial success with their first game, Checkout, despite having no prior industry experience and minimal marketing efforts.
- Checkout generated $28,600 in its first month after launch, with sales ranging from $500 to $1,500 daily after the initial first day.
- The primary reasons cited for its success include extensive polishing, its unique concept (standing out because "there's nothing really out there exactly like checkout"), and the belief that a "good game" naturally finds its audience.

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REQUIRED

Everything I Learned Releasing my First Game on Steam and Consoles

YOUTUBE | ~18 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=g-geVoA8Xr4&ab_channel=KyleBanks

This YouTube video features Kyle Banks, who shares his experiences and lessons learned from developing and launching his first indie game, Farewell North. He discusses the financial realities of indie game development, including cost management, revenue generation strategies (like console ports and bundles), and the critical importance of defining a game's genre and audience for effective marketing. The video also covers his insights on playtesting, scope management, and the often-overlooked aspect of developer well-being.

Highlights:
- Despite Farewell North being in the top 5% of games released in 2024 by revenue, its high development cost (over \$100,000) and long 4-year cycle made it barely break even, emphasizing the challenge of sustainable income.
Reducing costs by managing scope and development time is crucial; he aims for 18-24 month cycles and

advises designing for a 12-month development period.
Console ports (contributing 20-30% of total revenue for Farewell North) and Steam bundles (15% of Steam revenue) are substantial revenue boosters, but developers must weigh these against porting costs.
Clear genre definition and target audience understanding are paramount for marketing, as ambiguity can lead to confusion and hinder outreach.
Playtesting should begin early to refine mechanics, focusing on how players feel (aesthetics) and behave (dynamics) rather than just bug hunting. Mock reviews can provide valuable pre-release insights and help alleviate developer stress.
Developers should focus on the "core experience" or "fantasy" they want players to live out, keeping the game small but highly polished, and avoid scope creep.
Prioritizing physical and mental health is essential to prevent burnout from intense crunch periods, which can last for months.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

What it feels like to launch an indie hit

ARTICLE | ~19 MIN

https://www.polygon.com/features/2014/7/2/5858032/towerfall-matt-thorson/

The source article tells the compelling story of independent game developer Matt Thorson and his creative community living together in a Vancouver home known as Indie House. It details the journey of developing and launching TowerFall Ascension, a critically acclaimed multiplayer game that eventually brings its creator financial success and a half a million dollars in revenue. Ultimately, the narrative explores the tension between newfound wealth and the desire for relational stability, highlighting how Thorson values his shared lifestyle with close friends above the disruptive changes that come with commercial achievement.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Spelkollektivet: To Build a Castle

DOCUMENTARY | ~89 MIN

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Y4oBSm3QJk4

Spelkollektivet functions as a unique Swedish co-living sanctuary for independent game developers, offering a supportive environment where passionate creators can escape isolation and pursue their artistic visions despite intense financial pressures. The documentary explores how this communal space serves as a catalyst for profound personal healing and creative growth, allowing outsiders and trauma survivors to find a welcoming "family" that empowers them to finish ambitious projects. Ultimately, the video illustrates the fragile yet resilient nature of indie game development, highlighting how shared resources, emotional backing, and a refusal to conform enable creators to turn their wildest dreams into reality. There's also a short video about the space if you prefer. (https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TlTZBMq0HSo)

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Indie Games: The Movie

DOCUMENTARY

https://library.umaine.edu/auth/EZproxy/test/authej.asp?url=https://video.alexanderstreet.com/p/99BokP6XD

Description: 'Indie Game: The Movie' is a 2012 documentary film by Canadian filmmakers James Swirsky and Lisanne Pajot. The film documents the struggles of independent game developers Edmund McMillen and Tommy Refenes during the development of Super Meat Boy, Phil Fish during the development of Fez, and also Jonathan Blow, who reflects on the success of Braid.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Surviving Indie

DOCUMENTARY

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z7CWZhhBMSo&ab_channel=GamestarArts

This documentary offers a raw and honest account of the challenges and realities of surviving as an indie game developer over a 13-year period. The speaker shares personal struggles, including financial hardship and homelessness, emphasizing that passion is the only reason to pursue a career in games, given the low financial returns. The video underscores the importance of learning from failures, building a strong network, battling imposter syndrome, and adapting to the ever-changing industry landscape while retaining creative control.

Some highlights:

Working in the game industry demands immense passion as it typically offers significantly less financial reward than other fields, making it a "ridiculous place to work in" without genuine care.
Success in indie development is highly personal and involves enduring and learning from numerous "failed projects"; every successful indie developer has a history of setbacks.
The indie journey is often financially precarious and emotionally taxing, with periods of self-doubt (imposter syndrome), homelessness, and constant adaptation required.
Networking and community support are critical for survival, offering both practical assistance (e.g., a place to stay) and emotional resilience. Game jams are highlighted as valuable for rapid learning and skill development.
The speaker defines "indie" as retaining creative control and independence from corporate entities, regardless of team size or budget.
"Luck" in indie success is often the result of relentless hard work and being prepared when opportunities arise, debunking the myth of "overnight success".

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Is Madeline Canonically Trans?

BLOG POST

https://www.maddymakesgames.com/articles/is_maddy_trans/index.html

The creator of the video game Celeste explains that Madeline's identity as a transgender woman was unconsciously woven into the narrative while the author was personally navigating their own unrecognized gender struggles. Rather than relying on a dramatic public reveal or treating the character's background as a

superficial gimmick, the development team opted for subtle, respectful hints that mirrored real-life privacy and personal journeys. Ultimately, the author emphasizes that shared human emotions bridge the gap between cisgender and transgender experiences, proving that meaningful representation naturally enriches storytelling and fosters deeper empathy among all players.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 4: Students will be able to discuss ethical concerns surrounding gaming, including issues related to violence, addiction, monetization practices, labor concerns, and virtual identities.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

In Venba, gamers play as an Indian immigrant trying to restore lost recipes

ARTICLE

https://www.kcrw.com/culture/shows/good-food/food-video-games-vegan-history-america-passion-fruit/venba-video-game-immigration-assimilation-pj-shahamat

This article describes Venba, an indie video game by Toronto-based Visai Games, which delves into the Indian immigrant experience in Canada through the medium of food. Players assume the role of Venba, an Indian immigrant mother who settles in Toronto in the 1980s and attempts to restore her damaged mother's cookbook by reconstructing lost South Indian recipes through trial and error. The game features a linear story with dialogue options, and its main challenges revolve around the cooking process. The reviewer, PJ Shahamat, found the game's narrative deeply relatable, connecting it to his own parents' sacrifices as immigrants.

LO 2: Students will be able to critically assess how video games reflect and shape cultural values, norms, and societal issues.
LO 3: Students will explore the applications of video games beyond entertainment, including their use in medicine, education, and social engagement.
LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

In just one hour, Black Myth Wukong has smashed every other Steam game

ARTICLE

https://www.pcgamesn.com/black-myth-wukong/steam-launch

This article reports on the exceptional launch performance of Black Myth Wukong on Steam, noting that it broke concurrent player records within hours of its August 20, 2024 release. The action RPG surpassed major titles like Counter-Strike 2 and Cyberpunk 2077, quickly accumulating over 2.1 million concurrent players. The article emphasizes its unprecedented success as a single-player game, particularly highlighting that a substantial 88.1% of its player base is located in China, which aligns with its inspiration from the Chinese story Journey to the West.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The creator of Papers, Please wants developers to make weirder, more personal games

ARTICLE

https://www.theverge.com/games/651376/lucas-pope-papers-please-gdc-2025-pioneer-award

This article features Lucas Pope, the acclaimed solo developer behind Papers, Please and Return of the Obra Dinn, who recently received the Pioneer Award. Pope used his acceptance speech to encourage other

developers to create "unique off-beat, experimental, creative, and especially personal games," advocating for projects that stem from a genuine desire to play a certain type of game. He emphasizes that his own successes came from developing games he wanted to play himself, and he even involved his children in the development of his latest, more family-friendly title, Mars After Midnight, incorporating their "ridiculous" but core ideas.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

In its latest update, Enshrouded's terrifying monsters have players asking 'are we the baddies?'

ARTICLE

https://www.pcgamer.com/games/survival-crafting/in-its-latest-update-enshroudeds-terrifying-monsters-have-players-asking-are-we-the-baddies/

This article highlights the "Thralls of Twilight" update for the game Enshrouded, calling it potentially the game's best update yet. The update introduces new cosmic horror monsters and significant landscape improvements to the Shroud zones, along with new items and loot exclusive to these areas. It also overhauls nighttime gameplay by adding enemy patrols, night-specific gatherables, and vaults, and vastly improves the game's lighting. A notable aspect is the update's trailer, narrated from the monsters' perspective, which humorously yet complexly recasts players as "vicious killers," adding new texture to Enshrouded's lore about the Shroud and its creatures.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Wikipedia: History of Hytale Development

ARTICLE

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Hytale#Development

Hytale is a game with an interesting history, beginning as an indie game, then its studio (Hypixel Studio) was purchased by Riot Games, which eventually decided to cut its losses and cancel development of the game. It was finally released this past January just months after cancellation, due to the original founder of Hypixel Studios reacquiring the game from Riot Games, re-hiring many original developers, and rolling back several changes that had been introduced during Riot's ownership.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

'Into the Dead: Our Darkest Days' Blends 'This War of Mine' and 'State of Decay' Into an Engaging New Formula

ARTICLE

https://www.vice.com/en/article/into-the-dead-our-darkest-days-blends-this-war-of-mine-and-state-of-decay-into-an-engaging-new-formula-early-access-impressions/

This article offers an early access review of Into the Dead: Our Darkest Days, describing it as a survival game that skillfully blends elements of This War of Mine and State of Decay. The game immerses players in a zombie apocalypse where they must juggle resources, physical health, and mental well-being of survivors in their shelter while scavenging for supplies. It emphasizes risk-versus-reward gameplay, strategic planning, and the use of stealth and environmental advantages in combat against zombies. The review praises its polished presentation, fluid animations, and lighting, which effectively create a continuous sense of life-or-death tension.

The game is still in early access on Steam.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The Almost Gone review - dreamlike puzzles unlock a world of dark unease

ARTICLE

https://www.theguardian.com/games/2020/jun/25/the-almost-gone-review

This article reviews The Almost Gone, a puzzle-box game compared to Monument Valley or The Room. The game involves manipulating detailed miniature dioramas to solve visual puzzles and uncover a dark family story set in a liminal space between life and death. While the review highly praises the game's beautiful aesthetics, clean architectural design, and disciplined puzzle mechanics that make clue-finding satisfying, it notes that the storytelling is less effective. The narrative attempts to tackle too many heavy themes, such as addiction, abuse, and murder, in a short playtime, resulting in an opaque and less cohesive story compared to its engaging puzzles.

LO 6: Students will understand the variety of gaming experiences, from indie games to eSports, and will recognize the contributions of diverse communities within the gaming industry.

EXPLORE FURTHER

Little Nightmares, Limbo, and Others Are Drearios

ARTICLE

https://www.houstonpress.com/arts/defining-a-dreario-video-game-20233800

This article introduces a new proposed video game sub-genre called "drearios," a portmanteau of "dreary" and "Mario," coined by Jef Rouner of the Houston Press. This sub-genre encompasses games like Little Nightmares, Limbo, and Inside, which share common traits. The article outlines six criteria defining a dreario: a horrific or unsettling setting, basic linear progression, minimal combat outside of boss fights, a childlike player character, a focus on environmental storytelling, and a droning, atonal soundtrack.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

The food is… ME? - Dead Plate Full Horror Game

YOUTUBE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=MdB9Tdt99Io

This is a playthrough of Dead Plate, a short 2D restaurant tycoon themed RPG horror game with visual novel and point-and-click elements set in 1960s France following the story of a lively waiter named Rody trying to make as much money as possible in a week at a fancy bistro owned by a charismatic and successful chef, Vince. Please note the warning at the beginning.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Schedule 1 Proves How Important TikTok And Streamers Are For A Game's Success

ARTICLE

https://www.thegamer.com/schedule-1-tiktok-streamer/

This article examines the explosive viral success of Schedule 1, a drug-dealing simulator game, attributing its rapid rise to its inherent quality, engaging gameplay, and, most importantly, its virality driven by major streamers and short-form video platforms like TikTok. It highlights how accessible, shareable content, and multiplayer features contribute to a game's massive reach and sustained player engagement, even for solo developers.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Jeff Vogel: Making Games Alone For 30 Years, Unity vs Custom Engine, Indie Survival | Full Time Game Dev Podcast Ep. #046

PODCAST EPISODE

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=F9zYiHllEcU&ab_channel=ThomasBrush

This YouTube video features an interview with Jeff Vogel, a highly experienced indie game developer who has been making games solo for three decades. He shares his unconventional wisdom on surviving in the industry, including his commitment to building his own game engine, his philosophy on game polish, and his strategies for marketing and financial sustainability. Vogel emphasizes the importance of passion, resilience, and a deep understanding of one's artistic process.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Itch.io

WEBSITE

https://itch.io/

Play/explore indie games, such as those available on Itch.io (many are either completely free or offer a portion of the game as a free preview)

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Why ‘Untitled Goose Game’ Is the Chaos We Need Right Now

ARTICLE

https://collider.com/untitled-goose-game-switch-review/

This article reviews Untitled Goose Game, an indie title by House House, celebrating its delightful simplicity and charming mischief. It describes the game as a low-stakes puzzle experience where players embody a goose causing chaos in an English village. The review praises the game's easy controls, playful tone, and ability to provide a perfect, joyful escape from the complexities of the real world, distinguishing it from more intense or monetized gaming experiences.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Buckshot Roulette Developer on Making the Game Solo, Feedback & Success

ARTICLE

https://80.lv/articles/buckshot-roulette-developer-on-making-the-game-solo-feedback-success/

This article is an interview with Mike Klubnika, the solo developer of Buckshot Roulette. It delves into his creative process, influences, and the technical choices he made during development, such as switching to the Godot engine. Klubnika also shares his perspectives on what contributed to Buckshot Roulette's unexpected popularity and offers valuable advice for other aspiring solo game developers.

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EXPLORE FURTHER

Those we didn’t know are ‘Among Us’

ARTICLE

https://theaggie.org/2020/11/20/those-we-didnt-know-are-among-us/

This article discusses the explosive popularity of the indie game Among Us, which, despite being released in 2018, found massive fame in 2020 during the COVID-19 pandemic. It highlights the game's simple, accessible, and addictive murder-mystery gameplay. The article also notes how Among Us became deeply embedded in Generation Z's culture and was notably leveraged as a platform for political engagement, demonstrating its power beyond entertainment.

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